Driving Buy Flow Entries Through Dynamic Creative optimization in DV360

1. Business Objective

The objective of this campaign was to improve **Buy Flow Entry Rate (BFER)** at the **Middle Funnel (MF)** stage by testing whether **Dynamic Creative Optimization (DCO)** could outperform standard single-creative placements.

The client's goal was to:

- Convert impressions → site visits → Buy Flow Entries (Add-to-Cart equivalent)
- Improve cost efficiency (CPBFE)
- Maintain or improve engagement (SVR)

2. Platform & Technology Stack

🔹 **Display & Video 360 (DV360)**

A demand-side platform (DSP) used for:

- Audience targeting
- Media buying
- Budget allocation
- Real-time performance tracking

🔹 **Flashtalking**

A third-party ad server used for:

- Creative hosting
- Cross-platform tracking
- Dynamic Creative Optimization (DCO)
- Decision-tree based creative prioritization

3. Hypothesis

Thematic headline variations combined with automated creative optimization would significantly increase BFER compared to a control group using single creatives.

4. Media Setup

Component	Details
Platform	DV360
Funnel Stage	Middle Funnel (MF)
Audience	Broad MF Campaign Audience
Budget	$XX
Campaign Duration	8 Weeks
Placements	Multiple
Creative Structure	Control: 1 creative per placement / Test: DCO multi-creative

5. Test Design (A/B Structure)

This was structured as a controlled A/B experiment:

🅐 **Control Group**

- Single creative per placement
- No dynamic optimization
- Static headline

🅑 **Test Group (DCO)**

- Multiple thematic headline variations
- Flashtalking DCO auto-optimization
- Decision-tree prioritization of best-performing creative

The DCO engine automatically shifted delivery toward creatives generating higher engagement signals.

6. KPI Framework

- **Primary Real-Time KPI**
  BFER (Buy Flow Entry Rate)
- **Secondary Real-Time KPI**
  SVR (Sales Visit Rate)
- **Primary Post KPI**
  CPBFE (Cost Per Buy Flow Entry)
- **Benchmark**
  DV360 CPBFE Target: $XX

7. Initial Strategic Conclusion (From Strategy Team)

The strategy team initially reported:

- 80% increase in BFER from learning → optimization phase in DCO
- 52% improvement in control group
- Interpreted as strong support for DCO performance

However, this interpretation compared phases within groups, not true A vs B performance.

8. My Analytical Review

Upon conducting a direct A/B comparison:

Key Findings

1. **BFER**
   - Nearly identical between control and DCO
   - No statistically meaningful lift
2. **CPBFE**
   - Only ~0.5% difference between groups
3. **SVR (Secondary KPI)**
   - No observable improvement

Insight

The performance lift observed in DCO during optimization phase was not incremental versus the control group.

Both groups improved over time, suggesting:

- Algorithm learning
- Audience stabilization
- Funnel maturity effects

NOT creative optimization impact.

9. Final Conclusion

Despite internal claims of strong DCO performance, the true A/B comparison showed:

No material performance difference between static creatives and DCO for this MF audience.

Business Impact

- Prevented scaling an ineffective optimization approach
- Avoided unnecessary DCO licensing and creative complexity
- Saved approximately 50% of potential incremental creative budget

10. Strategic Recommendation

DCO should be used when:

- Creative variables are meaningfully differentiated
- Messaging personalization is required
- Audience segmentation is granular
- Product feeds or contextual signals are involved

In this case:

- Headline variations were not materially different
- MF audience may not be creative-sensitive at this stage
- Optimization impact was negligible

Future tests should:

- Include more aggressive creative differentiation
- Test DCO in upper funnel or personalized segments
- Use statistically powered sample sizes